

immediately" to "save Pakistan", also labelling the president a "one-man calamity". He has seen his stature rise in the wake of Bhutto's death, in particular because of the sober manner in which he has conducted himself. But that would hardly be of any comfort to Musharraf, whose entire post election plans seem currently to be in disarray.

In the middle of all this, however, all eyes are on the party Bhutto has left behind. There were fears that PPP could disintegrate without its "chair-person-for-life", so wedded had it become to her personality. Party insid-

tee's anointment of Bhutto's 19-year-old son Bilawal Zardari—now rechristened Bilawal Bhutto Zardari—as the new chairman of the party has sharply divided opinion in the country and, some say, within the party as well. The shy Oxford University freshman, was announced as the new head of the party in the Sindh town of Naudero after the committee endorsed an apparent will by Bhutto that asked for Zardari to be given the post who, in turn, passed on the mantle to his son.

COMING TOGETHER: PPP's Fahim (right) and PMLN's Sharif in Rawalpindi



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still needs about six years to be even eligible to contest a parliamentary seat—will not take any part in active politics and continue his studies at Oxford. Zardari has shown signs of political maturity—most people were impressed by his forceful defence of PPP's vision of the Pakistani federation in the face of emotional reactions in Sindh after Bhutto's death. He has earned his political spurs through more than a decade of incarceration on corruption charges that still remain unproven in court. But he is by no means a popular figure among PPP's rank and file and many party sympathisers blame him for Bhutto's fall from grace during the 1990s.

For now, Zardari claims he will not be a candidate in the elections and that Bhutto's feudal deputy Makhdoom Amin Fahim will, in all probability, be the party's prime ministerial candidate if PPP wins the polls. But there is a widespread fear that the resentment against Zardari's leadership—especially among veteran PPP leaders who have worked for the party for over 30 years—may cause a split in the party. There are already whispers of

blocs being formed in Sindh around leaders such as Qaim Ali Shah and Nisar Khuhro, while Punjab executive committee member Aitezaz Ahsan is an icon for many PPP sympathisers who were upset with Bhutto's decision to strike a deal with Musharraf, which was allegedly Zardari's brainchild. Ahsan had risen to prominence as the urbane leader of the lawyers' movement against the president and continues to be under house arrest.

"In Bhutto's absence, a strong PPP is a must for a strong federation," wrote analyst Ansar Abbasi, "Unity in its rank and file is vital for Pakistan. Otherwise, the losers will be too many." After elections were postponed, an angry Zardari too drew parallels with the loss of East Pakistan and ominously warned "Beware of the time when we cannot control our workers."



Erstwhile foes PPP and Sharif's party coming together is deeply troubling to the Government

ers were also whispering that it would be impossible for it to contest the polls. The party shocked everyone by not only holding together and organising a fairly smooth leadership transition, but also by bouncing back in a defiant mood. Denouncing the PML as the "qatil" or "murderer" league, Zardari announced that PPP was seeking to use the elections not only to reach the prime minister's office but also "to put Bhutto's picture in the presidency". Most analysts predict that the party stands to make substantial electoral gains if elections are held soon.

But PPP central executive commit-

To those justifying this transition, it was the only way to keep the party united at this time and ensure that the charisma of the Bhutto surname remained associated with it. To most independent observers, the transition smacked of a "feudal charade". "The Pakistan Peoples Party is being treated as a family heirloom," wrote activist-turned-author Tariq Ali.

Bilawal may be the heir to the Bhutto fiefdom but what is more troubling for some is that it is its regent, the controversial Zardari, who will in effect pull the reins of PPP leadership. Given his "tender age", Bilawal—who